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Hot and Noisy

Taiwan's Night Market Culture

Shuenn-Der Yu

EDITORS' INTRODUCTION

"Night markets" are periodic markets or fairs of a special kind held throughout the preindustrialized and early industrialized world, whether in France or Turkey, in Indonesia or Mexico. Night markets are in general more devoted to food and strolling with one's friends than are the more businesslike daytime markets. This is very much the case in Taiwan, and no town or city is to be found without one or more streets where people gather after dark to wander from food stall to food stall eating together. Among the food stalls, peddlers set out for sale miscellaneous goods of every description: clothing, kitchenware, antiques, books, DVDs, CDs, and small appliances.

Although established shops near a night market often sell their wares at the same time (sometimes outdoors), and although reputable small-scale merchants throng the crowded streets, there are also scams of every kind. Makers of sugar water tout its prowess in curing everything from indigestion to stupidity, and the public, knowing that there are no guarantees for night market merchandise, greet minor fraud with indulgence and continue to shop for bargains. Many night markets take place in squares and streets near temples, where some visitors like to stop to burn incense to the presiding deity along their way.

In Taiwan, the night market has always been a place of relaxation and social interaction, not merely a place to buy things. Taiwanese reflect on them with a certain nostalgia and memories of many happy hours strolling with friends in this ambience. For the merchants, however, the night market is hard work. It is potentially profitable, but it requires a good deal of as-

tuteness in selecting items for sale and considerable hustle in promoting them to a rather casual public, there to look but not necessarily to buy.

In this chapter, Shuenn-Der Yu describes the world of Taiwan's night markets, beginning with a song affectionately mocking the unbridled greed that, according to the song, informs their eager merchants. He distinguishes them from other kinds of markets, throwing into relief their social functions. In the course of the discussion we learn about how time and space matter to night markets and about the critical Chinese notion of *renao*—an amiable, noisy confusion that marks a celebration of life. We also learn of the world of small snacks suitable to cooking and vending at pushcarts. No Taiwanese can speak unmoved of Yuanhuan oyster omelets, we are told, and night market food, like the context in which it is eaten, is part of what makes life worth living. ■

Earn, earn, earn, more or less, earn, earn, earn! . . .
Any new fad, come here and you will find it.
Steak, *qieya* noodles, toys, cable TV decoders.
Pikachu and Hello Kitty.
Shoot the balloons and scoop up the goldfish.
Pop music or nude albums.
All made in nine-city. . . .

Strolling back and forth in the night market, buy as much as you can
So Taiwan will have a miracle.

The police car has left, brother policeman has disappeared.
Dear customer, what do you like? I'll give you a bargain.
It's lag season, I'm just earning some more or less.
What's popular abroad? Don't know? Come over here.
Grandma, Issei Miyake, cosmetics and sexy lingerie,
Cell phones and pagers. Diet teas and massage chairs.
We sell generic brands and we sell Nikes.
All made in nine-city. . . .

—Shi Wenbin, "Made in Nine-City"

Shi Wenbin's song touches on many issues of importance to Taiwan's night market culture.[1] Sung in Taiwanese, it underscores the notion of night markets as a core part of Taiwanese popular culture. But Shi borrowed the melody from a famous Middle Eastern song, "Persian Market," and added his own interpretation of the context within which the Taiwanese cultural institution is situated. His opening phrase, "Earn! Earn! Earn!" may be viewed as a Taiwanese self-portrait; it bears an ideological resemblance to the title of another local song, "Strive to Win" (Aipin cai hui ying).[2] Shi's song praises the work ethic that has brought prosperity to this island, while simultaneously poking fun at the current generation of hard-working Taiwanese as only knowing how to make money without caring about cultural matters. Fair or not, it is a frequently heard criticism.

A strong work ethic is only one of many important aspects of night marketing. Long hours are accepted as part of the lifestyle, especially as the country endures its current phase of economic restructuring that is adversely affecting petty entrepreneurs, laborers, and other workers at the lower end of the economic spectrum. Thus night market vending, seen in the 1980s as a potentially profitable business, is going through a period of decline, and there is talk that the "good old days" are over. Police regulation has served to further marginalize street vending as a viable means of earning money in the face of Taiwan's increasing modernity. Night market vendors are therefore reduced to using moral arguments (as reflected in Shi's popular song) when facing the police, who act on behalf of the state. The state, meanwhile, attempts to mediate among the diverse interests wishing to promote or restrict night marketing.

According to Shi's lyrics, customers need the right attitude, dress, and bargaining skills, as well as adequate cash, to enjoy one of Taiwan's most important consumption environments. So when there is good weather, people should "Invite Each Other to Stroll the Night Market" (Xiangyao lai guang yeshi), as the title of yet another popular song on this topic suggests, and buy as much as possible so that Taiwan's economic miracle can continue to thrive.

Today, night markets serve as spaces in which global cultural flows meet: Shi's mix of Mandarin, English, and Japanese terms within his Taiwanese verses, combined with a Persian melody, accurately reflects this important aspect of night markets. Thus, to adequately describe such a mixture and to understand night markets as a form of popular culture requires a consideration of the dimensions of time and space, in addition to an analysis of its activities and content.

DEFINING NIGHT MARKETS

It is difficult to give a precise definition for conceptions of night markets because of the associated mix of activities, merchandise, and complex meanings. Night markets in Taiwan range from the large-scale nightly metropolitan kind located in larger cities (e.g., Taibei and Gaoxiong) to the small-scale ones in urban residential neighborhoods and to the periodic markets common in suburbs, townships, and villages. A cultural definition of a Chinese night market basically entails cooked-food vendors using pushcarts or stationed in stalls. Without prepared-food vendors, these clusters of retail vendors operating at night would not qualify to be named night markets. In recent years, a steadily increasing number of restaurants and established shops have set up business in or around once vendor-focused night markets and have become an important part of night markets. This has also moved in the other direction, with vendors "invading" some urban commercial districts and turning them into "marketlike" spheres. The selling of products manufactured by Taiwan's small-scale industries during the past quarter century has become an important vending business in night markets of all types and has given night markets a strong commercial image. But as Taiwan's traditional manufacturing sector has suffered from increasing labor

costs and strong foreign competition, night market vendors and shops alike have increasingly become retailers for foreign imports. This is especially true for cheap imported goods (e.g., garments) from Korea and mainland China. Conceptually, night markets have a decidedly leisurely air, and they are distinctive from the morning or evening "vegetable" markets, which primarily sell groceries for daily necessities. Vendors in urban night markets normally begin setting up their businesses during the afternoon rush hour and work until midnight. Only a few remain open all night. Periodic markets generally open late, after normal dinnertime, and close one hour before midnight. The above features demonstrate that Chinese night markets are not merely any markets operating at night—they are specified forms with many complexities.

Strolling through night markets continues to be one of the most popular nighttime public leisure activities in Taiwan. Every evening, thousands of customers visit night markets to consume food, purchase merchandise, and try their hands at games of chance—or to simply enjoy the "hot and noisy" *(renao)* atmosphere that is a distinctive feature of Taiwanese night markets. Their popularity is such that they are found in medium-sized townships, rural villages, and even remote aboriginal settlements in the mountains. Regardless of location, their great popularity serves as proof that they exist as an important economic and social institution.

Chinese night markets made their first recorded appearance during the late Tang dynasty (in the eighth and ninth centuries) and quickly became a pervasive aspect of Chinese society. It was one of the earliest cultural institutions to reemerge in the People's Republic of China once the Communist Chinese government relaxed its strict societal controls in the 1970s. Night markets also spread to other countries with high concentrations of ethnic Chinese—Singapore, Indonesia, Thailand, and Malaysia. As might be expected, night markets reflect the economic and ethnic characteristics of the societies in which they exist: Singaporean night markets are highly gentrified and tightly controlled by the state, while major night markets in Hong Kong have been promoted for the international tourist trade.[3] Those found in Taiwan's major cities are cosmopolitan outlets attracting modern consumers, while those in smaller communities in Taiwan, Hong Kong, and throughout Southeast Asia are more parochial, consisting of a few food stalls that primarily serve crowds interested in socializing. All of these night markets share some common features: the cultural use of time and night markets' spatial meanings, food specialties cooked on the spot, and vendors selling products that link light industries with the popular cultures of their host societies. By examining some of these features in detail, it is possible to trace the evolution of night markets along specific cultural lines to their present form, as well as to understand their current status as a cornerstone of Taiwanese culture.

Despite their long existence in Chinese history, night markets have probably always been perceived as socially peripheral by the Chinese; unfortunately, there is a lack of evidence in favor of this argument from official historical documents. While county gazetteers have fully detailed descriptions of morning mar-

ket activities, we find almost no record of night markets. Surprisingly, a similar situation exists today: Despite the recognition of night markets' economic significance, local and national government bureaucracies still fail to keep detailed records of their activities. At the same time, while most morning markets have been brought under the direct control of government agencies, the state has shown little interest in attempting similar efforts for night markets.

Yet from an economic viewpoint, only in recent years has vending (including night marketing) been strongly condemned as an activity sabotaging Taiwan's economic and social well-being. This scenario can be depicted as an economic informalization tied to the marginalization of night markets within both economic systems and societal values that relegates vending to an underground economy *(dixia jingji)*. The status of night marketing has been repeatedly recategorized in economic and legal terms, but each time it was situated at an even more disadvantaged position. Previously, vending was classified as "open-air stores" *(ludian)*. Although it was under tight Japanese colonial control, it was legal. In the 1960s, the Guomindang (KMT) government perceived it as a "self-help strategy" engaged by unemployed and handicapped citizens. Thus it embodied a form of social welfare. But it was also criticized as causing "vendor problems"—that is, traffic and sanitation problems.

As modernization occurred throughout Taiwan during the past two and a half decades, the value of vending has been debated within the confines of the island's capitalist economy. Because the vendors evaded taxes and had low overhead costs, a discourse arose that accused vendors of creating "unfair competition" with formal stores. This recategorized night markets as part of the underground economy. This informalization process began in the mid-1970s and was connected with the historical establishment of capitalist economic practices and their associated value systems as societal norms. In contrast, night market activities began to be criticized as anti-modern and backward. Although Taiwan's government has never made vending illegal, vendors' increasingly disadvantaged position has nonetheless legitimated a great deal of police regulation with regard to relocation practices.[4]

Nonetheless, as the position of the night market is pushed further toward the social periphery, its symbolic meaning as a cultural institution seems to increase in significance. There are increasing numbers of night markets that are singled out as important symbols of Taiwan's remaining folk culture. Thus, they have increasingly become a typical site—along with temples, older neighborhoods, and a handful of local museums—for Taiwanese people to give their foreign guests and relatives visiting from other parts of Taiwan an "authentic" experience of local culture. Discourses attempting to define night markets' legitimacy and meaning shed light on them as places of competing interests and values. The struggle over their legitimacy as pleasure sites, a cultural activity, and an economic form is intrinsically tied in with social power relations deriving from multiple sources. These contradictory messages embody complex meanings worthy of anthropological analysis.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

In A.D. 836, the Tang dynasty government imposed strict sanctions on night market operations, an indication that the markets had already achieved significant levels of organization and sophistication (Chi and Liu 1987, 106). Economic expansion during the late Tang forced a decline in state regulation, leading to the lifting of curfews and other restrictions on commercial activity. During the Song dynasty (960–1279), night markets became an established part of night life in all of China's major cities, where they were increasingly found in "remote and quiet" corners (Meng 1980, 21). These markets frequently operated past midnight and into the third watch (3:00–5:00 A.M.), with some core area markets occasionally staying open twenty-four hours a day. In the famous book, *Record of the Splendors of Hangzhou City (Menglianglu),* Wu Zimu gives a detailed description of goods and services found in Hangzhou's night markets during the Song, including fortune-telling, gambling, juggling performances, a wide range of arts and crafts, fruits and vegetables, clothing, Buddhist icons, tea, and prepared "snack foods" or *xiaochi* (Wu 1980, 242–243). Many prepared foods and fruits were sold throughout the day by vendors and shopkeepers, but Wu identified certain *xiaochi* items (along with specific fortune-telling services) as "night market special goods." Song period night markets were also associated with restaurants and brothels, since they were frequently located along main business streets and near red-light districts. In *The Eastern Capital: A Dream of Splendors Past (Dungjing menghualu),* Meng (1980) gives a description of the northern part of Kaifeng city, in the vicinity of Maxing Street, where many restaurants and a large night market were located. During the Song, it was reportedly the only area without mosquitoes, since it was so full of smoke from hundreds of candles and oil lamps.

When Taiwanese mention night markets, the first impression is always about *xiaochi* food. (Photo by Shuenn-Der Yu)

The similarity between Song dynasty night markets and those currently operating in Taiwan is striking. Today's markets also carry a diversity of goods and services, as well as providing a regular leisure activity for a society very interested in nighttime public activities. Though handicrafts have for the most part been replaced by the products of modern light industry and luxury art works have been replaced by cheap, mass-produced imitations, Taiwan's night markets continue to be noted for their snack food specialties and for their position as gathering places for a diverse population. This cultural form, it appears, has been rather stable over centuries.

Taiwanese night markets first appeared as small, local markets operating in popular urban gathering sites. The oldest and most famous night markets still operating today—such as Yuanhuan and Wanhua in Taibei and Sakariba and Xiaobei in Tainan—all started as small gatherings of food vendors on street corners, in temple plazas, or next to early morning vegetable markets during the period of Japanese occupation. They were quickly joined by a handful of retailers selling such items as traditional medicines and handicrafts and eventually established themselves as part of the street culture that had been so popular in Chinese society.

In Taiwan, Taibei exemplifies the development of night market networks. While small gatherings of night vendors were common in pre-1949 Taibei, they were not considered night markets because they did not attain the spatial meaning of the Chinese definition of "market" (to be explained in the next section). Prosperity for this particular generation of vendors did not occur until after Taiwan recovered from the destruction of World War II. The first wave of new night markets slowly emerged during the 1950s in Taibei's older urban core and during the early 1960s in a handful of settlements on the city's edges. They then rapidly spread into newly established suburbs and manufacturing centers in several satellite cities during the 1970s. Further into the marginal areas of the Taibei metropolis were traveling periodic night markets, similar to those found in more rural towns. These market networks became so efficient that by the mid-1980s, a full range of goods and services could be purchased in even the most remote areas of the island.

During the 1950s and 1960s, Taibei's night markets (especially Yuanhuan and Wanhua) reflected the tastes of urban migrant laborers who found temporary housing nearby and who formed an important segment of the night market customer base. To serve their needs, vendors created simplified versions of banquet dishes and catered *xiaochi* foods commonly found in southern Taiwan. The names of their originating towns were frequently appropriated for the names of the dishes (e.g., "Zhanghua meatballs"). The vendors used simpler cooking procedures, stronger flavors, and cheaper materials to serve those who could afford only inexpensive meals on a regular basis. But the special position of *xiaochi* in Chinese cuisine (discussed in a later section) meant that these night market specialties eventually attracted the attention of the local elite. Even today, as a means of attracting new customers, vendors tell stories of famous politicians and intellectuals visiting their night market stalls. Later, such

stories became an important part of local nostalgic discourse, pitting modern images against older versions of night markets.

The mass-produced, inexpensive garments, shoes, ornaments, and toys for which Taiwan became famous and on which it built the foundation for its "economic miracle" were first sold in night markets in the early 1960s. The global recession of the 1970s actually improved opportunities for vendors to sell goods produced by Taiwan's family-based, small-scale light industries, since the number of canceled overseas orders made more products available to local markets. Vendors responded by promoting their merchandise as "returned export" and "export-cut," even for products that were in reality made for the domestic market. Taibei's Wufenpu area garment firms, which primarily produced inexpensive, low-quality clothing, used such slogans as "bankruptcy goods," "cut products," and "returned export goods" to capitalize on a market niche created by a new class of salaried urban office workers looking to buy readymade garments (Ka 1993). Vendors took advantage of this growing market to establish a night marketing network that continues to serve Taiwan's light industry today. These commodities replaced many traditional night market businesses, including Chinese medicines, handicrafts, and fortune-telling services. This in turn transformed night markets to embody the local as well as global modern popular culture that was created by commercial industries.

The increasing prosperity of night markets toward the end of the 1980s attracted higher quality garment and shoe stores to set up booths in night markets, leading to the further displacement of traditional businesses. During this period there was an increase in the use of neon signs, bright displays, and loud music by the stores to attract customers. This added to the overall energy of night markets. Cafeterias were replaced by restaurants, sundry stores by gift shops, and low-quality garment stores by sportswear outlets. Watch and clock shops became popular night market fixtures, as did optical stores. At the height of Taiwan's stock market surge in the late 1980s, various chains began to open franchises in or adjacent to night markets, including fast-food outlets such as McDonald's, twenty-four-hour convenience stores such as 7-Elevens, and many garment stores. The changeover continued into the 1990s, and many individually owned garment, shoe, and sportswear businesses were replaced by chains selling higher grade merchandise. Eventually, a few department stores opened branches nearby, as in the case of Taibei's Shilin and Tainan's Xiaobei night markets.

These changes transformed Taiwan's night markets from spaces that primarily sold traditional snack foods, handicrafts, and services into modern centers of popular culture. This led the way for postmodern juxtapositions of fads and temples, department stores and vendors, name-brand commodities and counterfeits, and convenience stores and traditional foods. Some markets are better known than others for rapidly responding to new trends, such as light manufacturing firms and their vendor outlets that try to capitalize on new fads by distributing their own embellished versions through night markets. This was especially true before the 1990s, with the lax enforcement of copyright and in-

tellectual property protection laws. Markets were flooded with counterfeit merchandise, which attracted thousands of young customers willing to buy cheap copies of fashionable items at a price they could afford. With greater emphasis on enforcing these laws in recent years, counterfeit copies of name-brand fashions and CDs are more likely to be found in smaller neighborhoods or in traveling night markets. Younger customers with disposable income still flock to the larger markets, however, bent on finding reasonable copies of fashionable items even if they do not have name-brand labels. With McDonald's, Nets, and Tower Records neighboring *xiaochi* stalls and temples and with vendors pushing counterfeit CDs, this night market scene does not appear to be exotic to Taiwanese. One informant even points out that this nicely complements the night market's original disorderly and spatial characteristics.

The above description demonstrates the fact that night markets have, however, had significant changes. Perhaps the most important of these changes is their articulation with the modern capitalist economy. Yet as a cultural form, night markets have actually been rather stable for centuries. I will now elaborate on the basic cultural principles underlying night markets' cultural forms.

UNDERLYING CULTURAL PRINCIPLES

Time

Temporality—what Kellerman (1991) calls the conception and use of time—is a key factor in any description of night markets. They hold special meanings that are congruent with Chinese concepts tied to the same time slot during which these markets operate. For Chinese, the hours following the evening meal have always been oriented toward leisure and public interaction, in contrast to the tendency of westerners to use evening hours for private pursuits or intimate interactions (Zerubavel 1981, 145). In terms of what Schivelbusch (1988) called the "temporality of night time," the historical significance of modern technology in the form of street lighting (dating to the 1700s in the West) appears to be irrelevant to the Chinese situation. In Western countries, gas and electric lighting completely changed the way in which nighttime was viewed—from "chaos, the realm of dreams, teeming with ghosts and demons" (Schivelbusch 1988, 81) to a victory over nature. In contrast, evening hours have been an important part of Chinese urban life since at least the Song dynasty, during which some restaurants, shops, and other activities peaked at midnight or later. Today, many commercial activities in Taiwan also continue into the nighttime hours, although most areas are empty by midnight. Nighttime, it appears, has always been the right time for leisure in Chinese society—and strolling down urban night markets has been an important aspect of nighttime leisure for centuries.

Important cultural distinctions exist between night and morning markets, despite their substantial overlap in terms of goods and services. Obviously, night market visitors are less likely to find vegetables being sold from vendor carts or the backs of pickup trucks. Similarly, there are also prepared *xiaochi* foods, gar-

ments, toys, and small appliances sold in the morning markets. Morning markets, however, consistently emphasize practical functions in contrast to the night market's leisure orientation. In Taiwan, morning markets are called vegetable markets *(cai shichang)* and primarily sell raw food and daily necessities. Their clientele, consisting mostly of housewives, differs significantly from the diverse social groups who visit night markets to eat, play, shop, and entertain dates. Some night markets are located next to day markets, but the former certainly engender more energy, entertainment value, and social and economic mix than the markets that used to attract the attention of anthropologists. The initial impression of many Taiwanese and foreign visitors concerning night markets is that they have entered a *fair* rather than a *market,* in the conventional sense of the word. This is especially true when the medicine sellers stage their magic or martial arts shows and the bingo stalls begin to attract crowds. It is also evident in the name applied to periodic night markets in many rural areas: "commodity exhibitions" *(shangzhan)*. Although it can be argued that this fairlike atmosphere is a part of morning markets too, shopping for daily necessities nonetheless appears to be drudgery rather than a pastime.

Space

The second principle focuses on the meaning of the term for market: *"shi." Shi* has traditionally denoted a concentration of buyers and sellers in a confined space. Today it is used to describe a retail rather than a wholesale market. It also implies a degree of heterogeneity of businesses in one place. No minimum number of vendors is ever required to establish an "official" night market, but a dispersed distribution of traders over a wide area would not qualify for night market status even if there were a significant number of vendors involved.

Rather than using a specific ratio of vendors per square foot, a more important criterion for what constitutes a night market is the unquantifiable ambiance created by such an assemblage. In Taiwan, small storefront merchants and vendors use such terms as "compactness of a market" *(jieshi)* and "formation of a market" *(chengshi)* to describe whether or not business activity is sufficiently concentrated, noisy, and exciting to be considered a true market. A successful night market must be "hot and noisy," the best translation of the term *"renao."* Vendors alone do not a *shi* make; it is only after a good number of customers have gathered and a *renao* atmosphere has been formed that a true *shi* emerges.

To Chinese people, *renao* is a key concept and an important feature of any successful celebration. It is considered embarrassing or foreboding to hold a wedding, banquet, or in some cases, a funeral that lacks *renao*—the emotion that transforms formal occasions into warm and interactive events. *Renao* is also considered to be a manifestation of the "human flavor" *(renqing wei)* that is generated from enthusiastic human interactions. A *shi* that is completely devoid of *renao* is obvious to even the casual visitor, but informants use the term as a vaguely definable criterion for determining the degree to which a group of ven-

dors have actually created a viable night market with acceptable levels of excitement and meaning. Dispersed businesses reduce the intensity of bargaining, which in turn reduces the sense of *renao*. Markets that fail to create this sense of excitement are said to be "chilly and desolate" *(lengqing)* or to have "dispersed *shi*" *(sanshi).*

Marketers use various means to create *renao*, the most common being bright lighting, loud music, and exaggerated decorations. Vendors directly address nearby patrons to get their attention. Some owners or their employees will stand on chairs and give their sales pitches through portable public address systems, with the volume turned high to make sure that they are noticed. Vendors also have a tendency to place their carts or stalls very close together, forcing customers to pass through narrow spaces that are close to the merchandise as well as the sellers. Personal space is difficult to protect in such tight quarters, with customers jostling for position in front of the more popular food vendors. During the peak periods of market activity, Taiwanese people often have to share a table with complete strangers when eating *xiaochi*. Food vendors are especially deliberate in their presentation, leaving raw meat, stomach and other organs, seafood, and vegetables open for inspection. Merchandise vendors are more likely to scatter their wares haphazardly, believing that a neat and tidy presentation is incompatible with the vibrant crowds, smoke, music, and the shouting that come together in a *renao*-filled market.

The sense of chaos that is encouraged among vendors operating on sidewalks and along the streets of night markets also extends to the stores behind them. Most garment and shoe stores eliminate shop windows or walled-off entrances. Instead, they choose to operate in an open storefront style, an arrangement which signifies a desire to integrate with other night market activities. Store shelves are arranged to give a sense of overflowing stock, similar to the preferred presentation of street vendors. The exceptions to this open-air storefront style are a few middle- and high-end restaurants and top-of-the-line garment stores whose owners want a purposeful separation from vendor activity.[5] These business owners, focusing on the apparent lack of regulations and planning in the market's spatial arrangement, would probably use the negative term for chaos—*"luan"*—to describe the same activities that most Taiwanese people refer to positively as *renao*. Attempts to make night markets conform to modern marketing concepts can actually work against them; those with formal rules, standardized stalls, and uniform appearances are in danger of alienating customers, some of whom complain about the loss of a market's character.

Spatial arrangements significantly influence behavioral patterns and human interaction. While customers remain strangers—even when sharing the same table—they are nevertheless attracted to the market by its crowds and the promise of safe participation in a shared event. This fits with Tuan's (1982) contention that individuals constantly seek a balance between communal life and isolation. He argues that as the consciousness of self has intensified in tandem with the development of modern society, people have tended to create spaces for withdrawal while simultaneously creating spaces for the reintegration of

communal life. The latter effort is evident in Taiwan's night markets. Customers enter temporary social relationships with clearly defined boundaries and ending points. Thus, night market *renao* is considered to be neither noise nor chaos. Instead, patrons caught in the energy and disorder of a market feel a sense of communal life through sharing a common space.

Night market patrons typically attend night markets in groups, within which interactions occur among people with established relationships. That, in addition to the anonymity of being in a crowded space, creates a feeling of safety that allows them to ignore the gazes of other customers and to act outside of their "normal" characters. A physical and emotional sense of relaxation leads to what many informants believe is undisciplined behavior, the thrill of which encourages return visits. Dressing down is perhaps mentioned more frequently than any other aspect of relaxed behavior—wearing slippers instead of shoes and shorts instead of pants is part of what night market strolling is all about.

While these points may seem trivial, they were repeatedly emphasized during interviews. Other frequently cited examples of relaxed behavior raised during interviews include eating while walking along a street, eating food in an inappropriate manner, talking and laughing freely in a public place, bargaining without considering one's own status, rummaging through merchandise without upsetting the vendor, and littering carelessly. All of these are commonly considered to be the actions of people from lower social and economic classes—except when they are done in night markets. In Babcock's (1978) words, such acts are "marked by an instability wherein the normative order is both presented and withdrawn at the same time." Such surroundings may be described as "ordered disorder" or "controlled decontrol." The transgressions are both minor and specific, but because they provide a sense of refreshment and renewal, the night markets in which they occur serve as significant sources of pleasure in daily Taiwanese life.

Food

Xiaochi foods have been a distinctive and indispensable feature of night markets ever since the Song dynasty. Descriptions of Song markets in Kaifeng and Hangzhou by Meng (1980), Wu (1980), and Zhou (1983) all focus on the surprising variety of *xiaochi* items that were available. Today they still constitute a significant portion of night market business. Providing the context and space for local gatherings, vendors offering local *xiaochi* specialties often become the focus and selling point of specific night markets. The special meanings attached to certain dishes are incentives for many Taiwanese to travel long distances in order to experience their flavors.

Understanding the important role of night market *xiaochi* dishes requires an explanation of their overall place in the hierarchy of Chinese cuisine. A loosely defined category, *xiaochi* includes all items that are not considered "rice or other staples" *(fan)* or "vegetable and meat dishes" *(cai)*. The Cantonese dim sum items, familiar to many westerners, are considered *xiaochi*, as are "steamed

buns with fillings" *(baozi)*, "Chinese dumplings" *(jiaozi)*, "rice cakes" *(gao)*, pork and fish congee, noodles, soups, dried foods such as nuts, and pickled fruits. Less traditional items include Western-style crackers, breads, cakes, candies, cookies, and ice cream. Flavored shaved ice is also part of this list, while soda pop and juices are considered *xiaochi* by some Chinese.

Central to the *xiaochi* concept is unity between *fan* and *cai*. In a typical Chinese meal, *cai* dishes are meant to *pei*—"match," "complement," or "supplement"—*fan*. In other words, *fan* is considered a basic, while *cai* is thought to be a supplement. The characteristics of *xiaochi* can be described in terms of *zhufu heyi*—a word that connotes the unification of "major food" *(zhushi)* and "supplemental dishes" *(fushi)*. *Xiaochi* is considered to be a separate category from "formal, regular meals" *(zhengcan)* because it is normally consumed as "snacks" *(dianxin)* between meals. *Xiaochi* items stand apart from this basic structure because they combine *fan* and *cai* ingredients. Western breads and desserts are generally considered *xiaochi* because they mix flour with flavorings; toast becomes *xiaochi* as soon as jam is added. In Taiwan, Western-style bakeries produce a variety of breads with such fillings as taro, red beans, or even powdered pork and fish. The northern Chinese custom of preparing "noodles without ingredients and flavoring" *(baimian)* to be eaten with the *cai* is seldom practiced among Taiwanese families. Noodles are normally—if not always—prepared and cooked with ingredients and flavoring and presented as a form of *xiaochi*, especially in restaurants and food stalls.

Another interesting example of how a foreign food is incorporated into a form of night market *xiaochi* is steak. Steak was at one time considered to be an expensive, exotic food sold only in Western luxury restaurants and represented to Taiwanese people a Western way of eating a meal. This consisted of soup as the first course, to be followed by salad, the main course (i.e., steak), coffee, and dessert. In the mid-1970s, a number of vendors began selling cheap steak meals, soon creating a major fad in Taiwan's major cities. Similar to Western restaurants, additional courses include soup, salad, bread, and tea (hot or iced), but not dessert. There is a notable absence of potatoes, and the steaks are served in one-eighth-inch slices. Unlike the Western steak dinner, in Taiwan vendor steak meals come with pasta and a raw egg cooked on a sizzling steak platter at the very last moment. The raw egg symbolically transforms the steak, vegetable, and pasta combination into something that can be considered Chinese *xiaochi*. In this process, starch (pasta) and supplements (steak and vegetables) are mixed together to reach a cultural definition of night market food. Like other night market foods, this vendor version of steak dinner is considered to be—and consumed as—a *xiaochi* instead of as a full meal. This became very popular in the 1980s and has become a regular food item in most night markets around the island.

Unlike the English term "snack," which refers to anything that can be eaten quickly and informally, Chinese *xiaochi* is loaded with cultural meanings. Most families make their own *xiaochi* only during major holidays—for example, sticky-rice dumplings wrapped in bamboo leaves *(zongzi)* are eaten by Chinese around the world during the Dragon Boat Festival; moon cakes accompany the

Mid-Autumn Festival, and rice cakes are eaten during Chinese New Year celebrations. On the other hand, *xiaochi* items are also commonly served at formal banquets, with Taiwanese hosts serving fried noodles or fried rice mixed with *cai* ingredients instead of plain rice as a special act of hospitality. A typical twelve-course banquet generally includes two or three *xiaochi* courses. Deluxe dishes remain the central focus of these occasions, but the addition of *xiaochi* items marks them as special events such as birthday parties and wedding dinners. *Xiaochi* dishes are also used to indicate the various stages of a banquet.

The informal aspects of making or eating *xiaochi* foods with friends or relatives are equally important. Many Chinese have experienced the intimacy associated with sitting around a table while making dumplings. In some ways, *xiaochi* foods serve the same function as barbecued foods in Western countries: Instead of preparing elaborate, formal meals for informal occasions, a host may substitute *xiaochi* dishes. In this way, they signify closeness in relationships. Eating *xiaochi* foods in cramped night market spaces is also indicative of intimate friendship.

These *xiaochi* foods were often created by people who were unfamiliar with the elaborate culinary knowledge held by the elite, which gave night market *xiaochi* a strong sense of being representative of local folk culture. It must be remembered, however, that night market *xiaochi* is not an exclusive product of market vendors or the middle and lower classes of society. As mentioned earlier, some deluxe banquet dishes were transformed into less delicate and affordable forms to be served in night markets. Unlike the many famous dishes representative of China's regional culinary styles, whose recipes are widely shared through popular cookbooks, night market *xiaochi* specialties are more restrictive in terms of locale and origin. Many foods are labeled with the names of the places where they were created as trademarks: Zhanghua meatballs, Tainan noodles, and Jilong fish cakes are all considered to be specialty *xiaochi* foods with authentic meaning. As such, they are depicted as special folk culture foods *(xiangtu xiaochi)* with their own distinctive flavors associated with their origins. Great gatherings of *xiaochi* foods also represent the exotic features of nonlocal cultures and ethnic groups. When Beijing reopened its night market in the late 1980s, it advertised the *xiaochi* foods of China's different provinces and various ethnic regions as its major attraction. In Taiwan, vendors constantly experiment with foreign foods from Japan, America, and even Middle Eastern countries in the hope of finding a lucrative *xiaochi* fad.

A detailed list of Taiwan's night market *xiaochi* is hence a representation of Taiwan's history, including traces of indigenous and successive foreign—particularly Japanese, mainland Chinese, and American—cultural influences. Japanese Udon noodles, mainlanders' dumplings, and American steak have all become typical food items in Taiwan's night markets, telling stories of Taiwan's colonial heritage, KMT rule, and a predominance of American and Japanese cultural influences. The localization of some of these transnational foods, like tempura (fried Japanese fish cakes),[6] are so profound that nowadays Taiwanese people often consider the food's authenticity in terms of *xiaochi* having originated at a

particular night market vendor. These foods have been very much incorporated into Taiwanese society—to the extent that we can scarcely tell which is "local" and which is "foreign."

Despite its diverse nature, however, night market *xiaochi* has always been illustrated as the representation of a Taiwanese indigenous culture by Taiwanese people. The story of oyster omelets is a typical example of how such a discourse is constructed. Oyster omelets were said to have been created by a famous stall in Taibei's oldest night market, Yuanhuan. The great success of oyster omelets has made this stall virtually emblematic of Taibei's night market *xiaochi*. Its locality name, "Yuanhuan," has become a brand name for oyster omelet stalls throughout Taiwan despite the fact that this snack food is also served in other night markets. Many of the food stalls use "Yuanhuan Oyster Omelets" as their title in a clear attempt to link their connection with the original. The oyster omelet was actually a famous dish in Xiamen (a port city of Fujian Province, the ancestral land of many Taiwanese). One stall owner claimed that it was his ancestor who transformed it into the current form by adding two new ingredients, a starch base and greens, to the original oyster and eggs. This Taiwanese version was a huge success and provided great income to the stall owners. Today the authentic oyster omelet served at this particular stall has become the object of nostalgia for many generations of customers. Because of this, they continue to pay special visits to the stall despite the fact that the prosperity of Yuanhuan has greatly declined in recent years.

A detailed examination reveals this simple change in preparing the oyster omelet to be surprisingly significant. The addition of a starch base that mixed the *fan* and *cai* components together structurally transformed a dish into *xiaochi*, making it a suitable food item for night markets. But the significance of this transformation was much more than a change in cultural categorization to adapt to a particular Chinese consumptive habitus—it opened the potential for profit. This slight change allowed a claim to be formed: an emergence of a *xiaochi* tradition that is indigenously developed in Taiwan. In other words, what we see is that the claim originated from an economic interest—their attempt to make distinctions for a commodity that was later to be utilized to designate a break from its Chinese heritage. In this way, the construction of an indigenous Taiwanese popular culture could be made.

The oyster omelet story is not a singular case. Stories of how stall owners strive to maintain authentic flavors have become an important aspect of the discourse linking night markets to indigenous folk culture. One example of this is the famous story of how one southern Taiwanese vendor has simply added ingredients to the same wok for over forty years instead of emptying out its meat sauce contents for cleaning. This nonstop simmering is said to give his Tainan noodles a special flavor found nowhere else. Such stories are abundant in tourist books, night market guides, magazine articles, and web sites, which often use night market (or *xiaochi*) "tales of marvel" as the subtitle. In the context of Taiwan's strong connection to Chinese cultural heritage, night market *xiaochi* is one of the few raw materials for which a discourse of indigenous Taiwanese tradition

could be well grounded. As Taiwanese consciousness began to compete with the orthodox Chinese identity represented by mainlanders and the KMT regime, night market *xiaochi* was naturally adopted as the source for raw materials upon which a Taiwanese identity could be constructed. This is most clearly demonstrated by Taiwan's new president, Chen Shui-bian (Chen Shuibian), who defeated the pro-unification KMT and PFP candidates in the year 2000 election. He used a few Tainan *xiaochi*—including three commonly found items from night markets—to mark his Taiwanese identity in representing a new political stance of government during the national banquet celebrating his inauguration.

Vending

Vendors are called *tanfan* or "small traders" *(xiaofan)* in Taiwan, which refers to small-scale traders using simple equipment to sell merchandise or services in streets or markets. When used as a verb, the Chinese character *"tan"* means "spreading out." Used as a noun, *tan* means "stalls" or "stands." However, *tan* can also mean having no fixed structure; spreading out merchandise on the ground also makes it a *tan*. Thus, the category *tanfan* refers to both stall owners and street vendors who use a stand, a pushing cart, or simply a piece of cloth for displaying merchandise. Being a vendor is an age-old profession in Chinese society. Many of them were engaged in many different businesses. Today, most night marketers are either retailers of modern commodities or vendors of cooked food; only a few traditional services, like fortune-telling and massage services, still remain.

Without vending, night markets could never achieve *chengshi*—the state in which a market is formed—and would therefore remain ordinary business districts. Vending embodies a form of commerce that is an important part of Chinese street culture. In those places where vending has not been absorbed by more formal business operations, one still finds spaces that contain special meanings in terms of informal business transactions, personal interactions, street performances, and leisure activities. At the same time, they are home to an efficient retailing network of distribution centers for goods produced by Taiwan's labor-intensive light industrial sector. The variety of goods and *xiaochi* foods sold by vendors in certain night markets has given them the reputation of "having almost everything." Even though vending has played an increasingly important role in Taiwan's modern economy, its legitimacy as an economic practice has suffered. Nevertheless, as vendors are pushed further toward the periphery, their symbolic significance grows.

As a long-established feature of Chinese culture, vending has always been viewed as an easy, flexible means of starting a small-scale business. Because they used public spaces, the first vendors adopted many of the professions common to Chinese street life such as fortune-telling, traditional medicine, and the selling of religious objects. Many of these can still be found in modern night markets. In rural areas, it is easy to find vestiges of the "itinerant peddler" *(pao jianghu)* tradition. Like medicine show operators in nineteenth- and twentieth-century America, these traders travel from town to town, staging dramatic per-

formances, martial arts, magic shows, and an occasional striptease performance to attract potential customers for medicines or traditional massage. The current versions of *pao jianghu* are used to promote such new products as multipurpose car wax or "miracle" toothpaste marketed by little-known manufacturers or trading companies that can be commonly found in urban markets.

Certain night markets are closely associated with local festivals, during which large numbers of vendors congregate to capitalize on their customers' high spirits. During the most important holiday, Chinese New Year, the police customarily relax their regulations and allow vendors to take over certain intersections and neighborhoods. The presence of vendors at festivals adds a strong sense of tradition in a country that is increasingly dominated by modern forms of popular culture. Whereas organized capitalism has tended to transform road space to accord with its own values, street vendors are often viewed as reclaiming public space for traditional street culture, rendering night markets a more distinctive place in Taiwan's contemporary economy.

Retail vendors, who are predominant in night markets, serve as channels for the flow of global products and culture. Popular forms of international fashion are normally marketed on a level far above the average Taiwanese night market. Yet vendors are quick to offer local versions of emerging fashion trends and fads produced by small-scale manufacturers looking to make a quick profit. While most of these products are direct copies (some even bearing brand name logos), many have slight variations in style, color, or material that match local tastes. This is a reflection of the ability of indigenous light industries to respond quickly to market demands and to take full advantage of the informal economic practices of night market vendors. Hence, night markets have a strong sense of being a culture created by commoners—that is, *xiaochi* vendors and small manufacturing firm owners—and are important consumption centers for the country's middle and labor classes.

Perhaps because of these counterfeit practices, night market vendors are frequently associated with the "low-culture" side of modern consumerism and are looked down upon as purveyors of low-quality merchandise and as symbols of a "greedy Taiwan." Even today, the simple act of strolling through a night market is seen by some as a marker indicating the low cultural standing of those involved. The selling of pornography, the existence of striptease shows, the promotion of gambling, and even the practice of bargaining at night markets are all viewed by elites and the government as vulgar pursuits that contradict the elegance of Chinese culture.

Societal perceptions of vending add another aspect to night markets. Vending is seen by many as a means for people to make the switch from laborer to "boss" or "business owner" *(laoban)*. Researchers who have studied Taiwanese and Hong Kong vendors (Smart 1988; Tai 1994; Yu 1995) have all noted that most vendors voluntarily leave their formal jobs to enter night market vending, believing that the economic prospects are better. The ability of night markets to attract crowds also makes them natural starting points for vendor success stories of near-mythical status. The mass media is quick to pounce on stories, regard-

less of their truth, of vendors making million-dollar incomes and driving imported cars.[7] A closer look reveals that these stories apply only to a handful of vendors in a few famous night markets. Night marketing has nevertheless gained a reputation as a way of life that has great economic potential, especially for those interested in climbing the ladder of social mobility. Thus, at a time when Taiwan was suffering from labor shortages (the 1970s to 2000),[8] instead of facing unemployment, a handful of extremely hardworking vendors dramatically demonstrated the potential of Taiwan's family-based entrepreneurship.

The idea of vending as a profitable business presents conflicting images. On the one hand, it strengthens the portrait of hardworking Taiwanese and the strength of family-based enterprises that underlie the discourse of the "Taiwan miracle." On the other hand, the result of this portrait provides the source of attack that vendors compete unfairly with more formal businesses. Despite the fact that the legitimacy of working in the streets can be traced back to a long history, vending has increasingly suffered from criticisms related to a concept that has in recent years been fashionably called the "informal economy."[9] The economic order associated with modern capitalism has transformed vending from being seen as a legitimate economic institution that has existed in Chinese society for centuries to what the state currently refers to as the "cancer of cities." Vendors are thus accused of creating disorder and evading taxes. Ironically, in Taiwan, it was only after night markets gradually became more formalized via an influx of stores, fast-food outlets, and department stores that were attempting to capitalize on the crowds attracted to the bargains offered by vendors that night market vending increasingly came under attack for allegedly using unfair business practices. The nature of the relationship between night markets, other sectors of the economy, and the state (via its publicly stated policy concerns) therefore complicates the issue of night market problems. Regardless of the true situation, vending is popularly viewed as serving a social welfare function in providing jobs for the poor, handicapped, and unemployed. As a result, a great disparity exists between stated policies and their enforcement. The ROC government has never been willing to directly confront a myriad of subsequent social and economic problems (i.e., numerous small-firm bankruptcies and their related unemployment) that would result from a concerted effort to control vending. Hence illegal vendor crackdowns are both ambivalent and ineffective, but the state continues to denounce vending through public education campaigns and media reports. Therefore, the relationship between night market vendors and government officials (mostly through police officers) rests upon delicate negotiations, bribes, and simply looking the other way. Today, night markets still play an important role in Taiwan's economy. This has been masterfully negotiated in under-the-table contracts between the state, which realizes its limited alternatives in dealing with vending problems, and vendors, who efficiently utilize what James Scott (1985) has called "weapons of the weak" to resist state attempts at regulation (Yu 1997).[10] The instability of these relationships shows that night markets continue to be sites of competing interests,

values, and power relations regarding their legitimacy as pleasure sites, cultural and historical repositories, and consumption centers.

As a result, night markets are positioned in an "in-between" or "neither-this-nor-that" condition—what Victor Turner (1977) termed "liminoid"—in the economic, legal, and cultural systems of Taiwanese society. Their "antistructure" exists through their temporality, consumer behavior patterns, spatial arrangements, interactions among various night market actors, and state policy. Consequently, the contrasting images of legal/illegal, legitimate/illegitimate, modern/traditional, vulgar/tasteful, fashionable/cultural heritage, order/disorder, and so forth tend to coexist in discourses that shape night markets as a popular cultural form. They are alternately described as places full of warmth and genuine personal relationships or as representative of aggressive, chaotic urban competition over cheap goods of questionable taste.

The counterdiscourse describes hardworking Taiwanese selling copies and counterfeits, night market *renao* energy arising from disorder, bargain-hunters' desire for fashionable commodities, modern urbanites enjoying city-centered recreation, and preservation of the "Taiwanese spirit." While doing my fieldwork I was repeatedly surprised at how these competing discourses coexist, sometimes in the opinions of the same person. Whereas in one aspect a night market might be praised as a source of folk culture, in another it would be condemned for promoting bad taste at the expense of traditional values. An individual might impugn popular culture as represented by night markets, but at the same time he or she might find it hard to resist going to famous night markets to enjoy some authentic *xiaochi* treats. Most people overlook the details of how they rationalize these discourses, thus allowing them to be swayed by different reasoning at different times. Unlike department stores, night markets have yet to be accorded a fixed status in Taiwan's society. These discourses have shown that as night markets are increasingly marginalized, their nostalgia and entertainment values are drawing cards that most Taiwanese find hard to resist. It may be their in-between status, characterized by conflicting discourses, that makes them the island's most popular cultural attraction.

NIGHT MARKETS AS TAIWANESE *XIANGTU*

Taiwan's historical context is such that a close bond exists between the issues of Taiwanese indigenous culture and ethnic identity. Most contemporary constructions of "Taiwaneseness" seek divergence from Chinese cultural heritage. The meaning of being Taiwanese, as Bosco (1994) rightly points out, is first in contrast to mainlanders, who came to Taiwan along with the KMT regime in 1949. Being Taiwanese thus becomes defined as Hokkien and Hakka speakers whose ancestors migrated to Taiwan before 1895. Because of Taiwan's current political and economic situation, a second meaning—in which being "Taiwanese" conceptualizes all residents of the island as a group unified in their dif-

ference from the PRC—has become important in the construction of a new Taiwanese culture. Based on his nice elaboration, I would further argue that a general state of anxiety exists in contemporary Taiwan concerning potential definitions of an indigenous Taiwanese culture. If Bosco's argument is correct that "the struggle between the orthodoxy of the center and the heterodoxy of the periphery has given way to the unorthodox cosmopolitanism of Taiwanese popular culture," then Taiwanese are certainly treating this popular culture with ambivalence. The country's recent shift toward democratization and globalization has intensified this general sense of anxiety, especially in regard to creating a central consensus from an increasingly pluralistic orientation.

One result has been a utopian construction of Taiwanese indigenousness known as *xiangtu*—a discourse that is frequently illustrated by examples taken from night markets and many other forms of popular culture. The construction is an ahistorical glorification of Taiwanese rural life and folk culture that offers small agricultural communities as its model. Similar to the ethnographic-present mode of presenting anthropological data that was adopted by the early functionalists, this form of discourse freezes time, space, and outside impacts when constructing an image of how Taiwanese would like their culture to be perceived. Hence, urban night markets are said to contain genuine human relationships of the type found only in rural villages and towns. Bargaining is described as an extension of personal relationships in a world marked by alienation, night market *renao* is said to represent a sense of freedom, and *xiaochi* is held up as an example of cultural authenticity.

A list of similar *xiangtu*-related constructions includes the consistent use of rural themes in Taiwanese television soap operas called *xiangtu* drama. These simple stories involving exaggerated figures emphasize traditional values in ahistoric settings. This is in direct contrast to Mandarin dramas that feature more complex stories that take place across a variety of geographic and period settings. In a like manner, Taiwanese antique furniture is called "folk-art furniture" *(minyi jiaju)*—a name promoting its local folk character but short historical depth—instead of "antique" *(gudong)* or "classical" *(gudian) jiaju,* which carries a connotation of mainland origins. A third example is the raincoats made of hemp or woven brush and rough-hewn cattle carriage wheels that have become common Taiwanese motifs in restaurants, teahouses, and other public businesses. In miniature form, they are one of the most common souvenirs given to foreign friends.

According to this *xiangtu* concept, being Taiwanese entails accepting cultural roots associated with rural life and values, manifested in what Taiwanese choose to show to foreign visitors as examples of a Taiwan experience. Along with the world-class Palace Museum (filled with artifacts taken from the mainland by the exiled KMT government) and a handful of historical monuments, night markets are often placed on the itineraries of visiting dignitaries to the island. The monuments and artifacts represent a connection with an older Chinese heritage, but night markets come under the broad definition of Taiwanese *xiangtu*. Just as Shi Wenbin points out in his song, the primary characteristic of

Taiwan's night markets is "all made in Taiwan's night city." The social construction of night market culture focuses on characteristics that can be described as "all made of Taiwanese x*iangtu*"—disregarding the fact that night markets originated as an urban phenomenon and currently serve as a crossroads of global cultural influences.

The emphasis on *xiangtu* has far-reaching impacts. Night markets have become cultural tourism sites emphasizing nostalgia, thus attracting visitors from every sector of the population wishing to partake of the attractive disorder. Many Taiwanese believe that if only the "vendor problem" could be solved, this "cancer of the city" could be turned into cultural landmarks instead. The idea of "tourist night markets" emerged exactly from this context. This new model was jointly developed in 1986 by some businessmen from Taibei's Songshan area, hoping to establish a night market to draw customers to the declining Raohe Street business district. This model was also supported by some scholars invited to propose a night market project that would later gain city government approval. The original attempt, however, was not to transform the night market to attract more foreign tourist consumers, as the title "tourist night market" may imply. Its actual effort was to redefine the boundaries of order/disorder and legal/illegal by establishing a system to regulate internal affairs, thereby reducing sanitation and traffic problems. By reorienting the night market, it was hoped that it would be more in line with a stereotypical *xiangtu* culture, via such folk-art performances as lion dances, giant top-spinning *(tuoluo)* shows, traditional figure-making demonstrations using dough, and handicrafts. Besides finding a solution for the increasingly marginalized urban night markets, this new tourist night market model also strengthens the conception that night markets represent indigenous Taiwanese folk culture. As this is the only model acceptable to both local governments and residents in allowing the continual operation of existing markets, many night markets have attempted to transform themselves into this "modernized" form in recent years. In 1998 the government also proposed a five-year project to gentrify morning and night markets across the island. Its first targets were the large morning and night markets in major cities. The establishment of Taibei's Donghua tourist night market in 1999 was one of the outcomes. Although the entire impact of this project still remains to be accessed, the trend is clearly established.

An enduring influence may be the creation of more tourist night markets as an official form of this unique brand of economic activity. The state's approval of tourist night markets as model examples of the preservation of folk culture marks a trend toward limiting night markets—especially those in big cities—to specific sites as legitimate leisure centers. This trend marks the continuing fragmentation of night markets into sites for folk-art performances, trade shows, and *xiaochi* exhibitions that are more in line with modern standards of order and control. As a result, instead of preserving a carnival atmosphere organized by the people for the people, many night markets may become carnivals controlled by the establishment for the people. If this trend continues, the days of the truly hot and noisy night market may soon be a thing of the past.